



Think Small, Dream Big....

Four mini-gadgets following that line of thinking...

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Once upon a time, making a call required the use of a grandfather of an instrument called the telephone; watching a movie meant the theatre, or patiently waiting for good old Doordarshan to show one; and for reminders, you circled your calendar.

Companies have always wooed customers by introducing features that would compete with our age-old devices. The future seems to be very different though. The emphasis is on tiny, and the shift is towards multi-tasking. All devices target the individual, who has grown up with technology, and is willing to pay to talk, touch, hear, see and sense at the same time.

Giving you a glimpse of what's in store for you are four devices that will change your life forever.

PDAs

Personal Digital Assistants (PDAs) are digital diaries, albeit a much superior version. PDAs come with processors, RAM and also add-ons such as modems, wireless keyboards, expansion cards, etc. They manage your address book, remind you of important tasks, do necessary calculations, and have a ready notepad for you to take notes. The high-end PDAs enable you to access your Outlook e-mail, browse the Web and chat. If you are bored, some PDAs have MP3 players and 3D games. Palm OS, an old horse at handhelds, has many options suitable to the varied needs of economics.

Personal entertainment devices

The Apple iPod can store up to 10,000 songs and it fits in your palm. Marvelous, isn't it? The days of Sony Walkman and MP3 players seem *passé* as companies such as Samsung and even Microsoft vie to bring out pocket-sized audio and video. For the entertainment and music industry, these are important innovations as they will influence the manner

in which entertainment companies sell their music and movies.

Smart Phones

Mobile phones have invented the need-to-stay-connected professionals, and they just got smarter. Check out Nokia's 6600 or Sony Ericsson's P900, and you'll never settle for less. All smart phones work like mini PDAs with e-mail, Internet and the Internet Messenger using such technology as Mac iSync software, WAP 2.0 and HTML browser. The Symbian Operating System allows you to add other third-party software of your choice. These innovations have affected other industries such as PCs, gaming and Web Services, who will now make devices and applications compatible with cell phones.

Does this mean a PC less future? Let's wait and watch.



Gaming Machines

According to Jupiter Research forecast, the audience for portable gamers will grow from 23 million in 2003, to 43 million in 2009. This means gaming companies have to incorporate newer technologies for their loyal fans. And no one wants to lag behind. Nintendo has already unveiled a prototype for its next generation DS hand-held model, which will include additional capabilities such as dual screens and voice recognition, intended to make game play more compelling. Sony, on the other hand, believes that high screen resolution and fast processors in its upcoming PSP (PlayStation Portable) will attract players beyond the age range of children and adolescents—currently the largest users of portable video game players.

There is also Nokia's handheld and Microsoft's Xbox. Today's gaming platforms are already realistic and these interactive gaming consoles are all set to usher in a gaming community that's up and running, blowing away their next target as they travel to work.



CHEAPLIST

LCD Screens

LCD prices are falling! Today, an entry-level 15-inch LCD costs about Rs 18,000. Though much higher than CRTs, at least they're within reach of the Indian PC buyer.

MFDs

94,000 inkjet-based MFDs and 20,000 laser-based MFDs were sold in India in 2003. Today the entry-level inkjet-based MFD costs as little as Rs 5,000. However, most laser-based MFDs are still out of reach of the Indian buyer.

Digicams

A two mega-pixel digital camera costs about Rs 5,000—pretty affordable. It's no wonder that the Indian consumer bought 1,05,000 units in 2003, and this figure is expected to nearly double this year.